

INTERNET SAFETY FOR SENIORS

Protect Yourself Online

A Plain-English Guide to Staying Safe
on the Internet, Email, and Social Media

By

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Internet Safety for Seniors - Protect Yourself Online

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Topic 1: Recognizing Scam Emails

- Look for misspellings and poor grammar in the email.
- Check the sender's email address carefully - scammers use fake addresses.
- Be suspicious of urgent language like 'Act now!' or 'Your account is locked!'
- Never click links in emails from unknown senders.
- Hover over links to see where they really go before clicking.
- Legitimate companies will never ask for your password by email.
- If an email offers money or prizes you did not enter to win, it is a scam.
- When in doubt, call the company directly using the number on their website.
- Forward suspicious emails to the company's fraud department.
- Delete scam emails - do not reply or unsubscribe (this confirms your address).

Topic 2: Creating Strong Passwords

- Use at least 12 characters - longer is always stronger.
- Mix uppercase letters, lowercase letters, numbers, and symbols.
- Never use personal information like birthdays, pet names, or addresses.
- Avoid common words like 'password', '123456', or 'qwerty'.
- Use a different password for each important account.
- Consider using a passphrase: 'My-Dog-Loves-Walks-At-7pm!' is very strong.
- Write passwords in a secure physical notebook kept in a safe place.
- Consider a password manager app to remember all your passwords.
- Change passwords immediately if you suspect any account was compromised.
- Never share passwords with anyone, even family members for shared accounts.

Topic 3: Safe Online Shopping

- Only shop on websites that show a padlock icon in the browser address bar.
- Look for 'https://' at the beginning of the web address (the 's' means secure).
- Stick to well-known retailers like Amazon, Walmart, and Target online.
- Read customer reviews before buying from unfamiliar sellers.
- Use a credit card instead of debit card for better fraud protection.
- Never save your credit card information on websites you rarely use.
- Be wary of deals that seem too good to be true - they usually are.
- Check the return policy before purchasing anything.
- Keep records of all online purchases and confirmation emails.
- Monitor your bank statements weekly for unauthorized charges.

Topic 4: Social Media Privacy

- Set your profile to 'Friends Only' so strangers cannot see your posts.
- Never post your home address, phone number, or daily schedule.
- Be careful about posting vacation photos while you are away from home.
- Do not accept friend requests from people you do not know in real life.
- Review your privacy settings at least every few months.
- Be cautious about quizzes that ask personal questions (maiden name, first pet).
- Never share photos of financial documents, IDs, or boarding passes.
- Remember that anything you post online can be seen by anyone eventually.
- Turn off location sharing on posts so people cannot track where you are.
- If someone you know is acting strange online, call them - their account may be hacked.

Topic 5: Spotting Fake Websites

- Check the web address carefully - scammers use similar-looking URLs.
- Look for misspellings in the website name (amaz0n.com instead of amazon.com).
- Legitimate websites have professional design without broken images.
- Check if the website has a physical address and phone number listed.
- Search the company name plus 'scam' or 'reviews' to check reputation.
- Be suspicious of websites that only accept wire transfers or gift cards.
- Look for a privacy policy and terms of service at the bottom of the page.
- If a website pops up saying your computer is infected, close it immediately.
- Bookmark your important websites so you always go to the real one.
- When in doubt, type the web address yourself rather than clicking a link.

Topic 6: Two-Factor Authentication Explained

- Two-factor authentication (2FA) adds a second layer of security to your accounts.
- Even if someone steals your password, they cannot get in without the second factor.
- The most common second factor is a code sent to your phone by text message.
- When you log in, you enter your password then the code from your phone.
- Enable 2FA on your email, bank, and social media accounts first.
- Some services use an app like Google Authenticator instead of text messages.
- Keep a backup phone number or recovery codes in case you lose your phone.
- 2FA takes an extra 10 seconds but makes your account much more secure.
- Most banks and email providers offer 2FA in their security settings.
- Think of 2FA like a double lock on your front door - extra protection.

Topic 7: Protecting Personal Information

- Never share your Social Security number online or by email.
- Be cautious about what personal details you post on social media.
- Shred physical mail that contains personal or financial information.
- Do not give personal information to callers who contact you first.
- Legitimate organizations already have your info - they will not ask for it again.
- Be careful filling out online forms - only provide required information.
- Check your credit report annually for accounts you did not open.
- Use a separate email address for signing up for newsletters and promotions.
- Be wary of free WiFi that asks for personal details to connect.
- Review which apps on your phone have access to your contacts and photos.

Topic 8: Public WiFi Dangers

- Public WiFi in cafes, airports, and hotels is not secure.
- Hackers can see what you do on public WiFi if it is not encrypted.
- Never access your bank account or make purchases on public WiFi.
- Turn off automatic WiFi connection on your phone in public places.
- If you must use public WiFi, use a VPN (Virtual Private Network) for protection.
- Verify the network name with staff - hackers create fake hotspots.
- A fake hotspot might be named 'Free_Airport_WiFi' to trick you.
- Use your phone's mobile data instead of public WiFi for sensitive tasks.
- Forget public networks after using them so your phone does not reconnect.
- At home, make sure your own WiFi has a strong password to prevent unauthorized access.

Topic 9: Recognizing Phone Scams

- If a caller says you owe money and must pay immediately, it is a scam.
- The IRS and government agencies communicate by mail, not threatening phone calls.
- Never give credit card or bank information to someone who calls you.
- Scammers can fake caller ID to show a real company's phone number.
- If someone claims to be from your bank, hang up and call the number on your card.
- Be suspicious of calls saying a grandchild is in trouble and needs money.
- Never pay anything with gift cards - this is always a scam method.
- Register your number on the Do Not Call list at donotcall.gov.
- Let unknown numbers go to voicemail - legitimate callers leave messages.
- Report scam calls to the FTC at reportfraud.ftc.gov.

Topic 10: Keeping Devices Updated

- Software updates fix security holes that hackers can exploit.
- Turn on automatic updates for your phone, tablet, and computer.
- On iPhone: Settings > General > Software Update > Automatic Updates.
- On Android: Settings > System > System Update.
- On Windows: Settings > Update & Security > Windows Update.
- Update your web browser regularly - it is your gateway to the internet.
- Update apps from the App Store or Play Store at least weekly.
- Restart your devices after updates to complete the installation.
- Old devices that no longer receive updates should be replaced.
- Updates may add new features too, not just security fixes.

Topic 11: Safe Video Calling

- Only accept video calls from people you know and trust.
- Make sure your background does not show personal information or valuables.
- Use meeting passwords when hosting video calls on Zoom or similar.
- Do not share meeting links on social media - use direct invitations.
- Mute your microphone when not speaking to prevent accidental sharing.
- Be aware that others can take screenshots during video calls.
- Keep your video calling software updated to the latest version.
- Cover your camera with tape or a cover when not using video calls.
- If an unknown person joins your call, remove them immediately.
- Use the waiting room feature so you can approve who joins.

Topic 12: Avoiding Malware

- Malware is harmful software that can damage your device or steal data.
- Never download software from pop-up ads or unknown websites.
- Only download apps from official app stores (Apple App Store, Google Play).
- Do not open email attachments from unknown senders.
- Install antivirus software and keep it updated on your computer.
- Be cautious of free software that seems too good to be true.
- If your device suddenly runs slowly, it might have malware.
- Pop-ups saying 'Your computer is infected, call this number' are themselves scams.
- Regularly back up your important files to an external drive or cloud.
- If you think you have malware, disconnect from the internet and run a scan.

Topic 13: Protecting Financial Info Online

- Only use your bank's official app or website for online banking.
- Look for the padlock icon and 'https://' before entering financial details.
- Set up account alerts for any transaction over a small amount like \$25.
- Check your bank and credit card statements at least weekly.
- Never email financial information like account numbers or tax forms.
- Use strong, unique passwords for all financial accounts.
- Enable two-factor authentication on all bank and investment accounts.
- Be suspicious of emails claiming to be from your bank asking you to log in.
- Bookmark your bank's website and always use that bookmark to visit.
- Consider freezing your credit if you do not plan to apply for new loans.

Topic 14: Recognizing Deepfakes

- Deepfakes are fake videos or audio made with AI to look real.
- They can make it look like someone said something they never did.
- Be skeptical of shocking videos shared on social media.
- Look for unnatural facial movements or lip syncing that seems off.
- Check if the content appears on legitimate news sources.
- Scammers may use AI voice cloning to impersonate family members.
- If a family member calls asking for money, verify by calling them back.
- Establish a family code word that only real members would know.
- Video quality that looks slightly blurry or waxy may be a deepfake.
- When in doubt, verify information through multiple trusted sources.

Topic 15: Safe App Downloads

- Only download apps from Apple App Store or Google Play Store.
- Read the app description and check the developer's name carefully.
- Look at the star rating and read recent reviews from other users.
- Check what permissions the app requests - a flashlight does not need your contacts.
- Be suspicious of apps with very few downloads or reviews.
- Avoid apps that promise free versions of things that normally cost money.
- Delete apps you no longer use - they can still access your data.
- Keep all apps updated to get the latest security patches.
- If an app asks for too much personal information, do not use it.
- Stick to well-known apps recommended by people you trust.

Topic 16: Email Safety Tips

- Do not open attachments from people you do not know.
- Be suspicious of emails with generic greetings like 'Dear Customer'.
- Legitimate companies will address you by your actual name.
- Never click 'unsubscribe' in spam emails - it confirms your address is active.
- Check the sender's full email address, not just the display name.
- Be wary of emails creating urgency: 'Your account expires in 24 hours!'
- When in doubt, go directly to the company's website instead of clicking links.
- Mark spam emails as spam so your email learns to filter them.
- Use separate email addresses for personal and promotional sign-ups.
- Enable your email's spam filter and check spam folder occasionally for real mail.

Topic 17: What to Do If You Are Hacked

- Change your passwords immediately, starting with email and banking.
- Enable two-factor authentication on all important accounts.
- Check your bank accounts for unauthorized transactions.
- Contact your bank immediately if you see charges you did not make.
- Run a full antivirus scan on your computer and phone.
- Check if your email is sending messages you did not write.
- Notify your contacts that your account was compromised.
- Place a fraud alert on your credit reports through the three bureaus.
- File a report with the FTC at [identitytheft.gov](https://www.ftc.gov/identitytheft) if your identity was stolen.
- Consider getting professional help from your device manufacturer or a tech expert.

Topic 18: Protecting Grandchildren Online

- Talk to grandchildren about never sharing personal info with strangers online.
- Help parents set up parental controls on devices grandchildren use.
- Know which apps and games grandchildren are using.
- Be a safe person they can come to if something online makes them uncomfortable.
- Do not post photos of grandchildren with identifying information.
- Avoid posting their school name, team, or regular schedule.
- Teach them that not everyone online is who they say they are.
- Encourage open conversations about their online experiences.
- Learn about the platforms they use so you can guide them.
- Set a good example by practicing safe internet habits yourself.

Topic 19: Reporting Scams

- Report internet fraud to the FTC at reportfraud.ftc.gov.
- Report email scams by forwarding to spam@uce.gov.
- Report phone scams to the FTC and your phone carrier.
- Contact your local police for scams involving financial loss.
- Report identity theft at identitytheft.gov for a recovery plan.
- Notify your bank immediately if financial accounts are compromised.
- Report social media scams using the platform's report feature.
- Save evidence: screenshots of messages, emails, and phone numbers used.
- Warn friends and family about scams you encounter.
- Do not feel embarrassed - scammers are professionals who trick millions of people.

Topic 20: Quick Reference Safety Checklist

- ☐ I use strong, unique passwords for every important account.
- ☐ I have two-factor authentication enabled on email and banking.
- ☐ I keep all my devices and apps updated with the latest software.
- ☐ I never click links in suspicious emails or text messages.
- ☐ I do not share personal information with unknown callers.
- ☐ I check my bank statements regularly for unauthorized charges.
- ☐ I only download apps from official app stores.
- ☐ I do not use public WiFi for banking or shopping.
- ☐ I have antivirus software installed and updated on my computer.
- ☐ I know who to call if I think I have been scammed (bank, FTC, police).